



A BOARD GAME OF ISLANDS, ARMIES AND AMBITION

MEDIEVAL CIVILIZATION

COVER ART GOES HERE

— DRAWN BY US, ENHANCED BY DAD —

DESIGN PACKET · NIGHT ONE

31 JULY 2026 · EVERYTHING WE SAID, WRITTEN DOWN

This is your first design session, sorted into sections. Everything in the main column is **your idea**, taken from what the two of you actually said out loud on 31 July.

The gold notes in the margin are **suggested answers** to problems you raised but did not finish. They are suggestions only. Cross out any you disagree with — you are the designers, and a rule you argued over will always beat a rule handed to you.

BEFORE YOU TRUST A LINE

The recording was rough in places, so a few sentences were reconstructed from context. If a rule below sounds like something neither of you said, it is probably a mis-hearing — fix it in pen and it becomes right.

0.1 Who plays first

The two of you play the very first game. One of you sits out as the **Rules Helper** instead of taking a kingdom — reading rules aloud, settling arguments, and writing down anything that feels broken. Then you teach Mom and Dad.

0.2 The deadline

Playable before the end of the school year. That is enough time if you build the small version first (see § 9).

0.3 Where it came from

This is your favourite video game turned into something you can hold. Where a rule was already decided in *Medieval RTS*, we kept it, so the board game and the computer game feel like one world.

YOUR QUESTION

“Are we ready to make the list of stuff now — have we done enough to start planning and making it?”

SIDE ANSWER

Yes. You settled movement, boats, transport and buildings in one sitting — that is the hard half. § 9 is your shopping list and build order. Start cutting hexes this week.

SIDE ANSWER

Being Rules Helper is not sitting out. Whoever does it will understand the game best and will win most of the games afterwards.

“So should we do hexagons — maybe we separate each island into 20 hexagons... and the whole ocean will be hexagons, right, just like the land.”

1.1 Everything is hexagons

Land and sea are both hex grids. One hexagon is the unit of distance for every rule in this packet.

1.2 Islands are 20 hexagons

Each island is made of exactly **20 land hexes**. Every player gets one island, and starts with a **castle** on it.

1.3 The ocean between

Ocean hexes fill the space between islands. Boats move on them; soldiers cannot enter them without a transport (§ 4).

1.4 Face-down exploring

Ocean and unclaimed land tiles start **face down** and flip when someone reaches them. Nobody knows the whole map at the start.

1.5 Built like a blueprint

The board is layered: the island underneath, the people and buildings on top of it.

LEFT OPEN

How many islands, and how far apart?

SIDE ANSWER

One island per player, arranged around a shared ocean. Leave **4–6 ocean hexes** between neighbours: far enough that invading is a real decision, close enough that a 10-hex boat move (§ 4.1) can cross in one go.

SIDE ANSWER

Put 2–3 small **unclaimed islands** (5 hexes each) in the middle. They give the fleet somewhere to go besides straight at each other, and they are what makes exploring worth doing.

SIDE ANSWER

Hex sizes: cut them about **1.5 inches** across. Big enough to stand several soldiers on, small enough that 20 of them fit a poster board.

“You have two move tokens, one build token and one attack token.” · “Tokens are for moving and placing stuff — and then the attacking is where you roll the dice.”

2.1 Four tokens a turn

Every turn you get the same four tokens. Spend them in any order, then your turn ends. Unspent tokens do not carry over.

TOKEN	WHAT IT BUYS
Move ×2	Move a group up to 5 land hexes, or a fleet up to 10 ocean hexes
Build ×1	Place one building, or upgrade one building
Attack ×1	Start one fight — the fight itself is settled with dice

2.2 Tokens move, dice decide

This is the heart of the game. **Tokens are for moving and placing.** Once a fight starts, tokens stop mattering and the dice take over (§ 5).

2.3 Distance costs time

Because one move token only carries you 5 hexes, crossing your own island takes real turns. That delay is deliberate — it is what makes far-away land feel far away.

LEFT OPEN

Who goes first, and how do you collect resources?

SIDE ANSWER

Everyone rolls one die at the start; highest goes first, then play clockwise. Re-roll ties.

SIDE ANSWER

Add a free **Harvest step** at the start of each turn, before you spend tokens: collect resources from every hex you own. It costs no token, so gathering never competes with moving.

SIDE ANSWER

Keep the token count at four for the first playtest even if turns feel short. It is far easier to add a fifth token later than to take one away once you are used to it.

“It would be painful to move the whole army one person at a time.” · “Over four people it takes two move tokens to move five spaces of that whole army — technically more efficient than moving one at a time.”

3.1 Five hexes per move token

One move token moves a unit up to **5 hexes**, in any direction, including diagonally. Somewhere 6 hexes away cannot be reached with a single token, no matter what.

3.2 Small groups: up to four

Up to **4 soldiers** standing together move as one group for one move token.

3.3 Big armies: five or more

An army of **5 or more** costs **both** move tokens — but the whole army moves at once, however big it is. With 20 or 30 soldiers this is enormously better than shuffling them one at a time.

WHY THIS RULE IS GOOD

It solves the boring problem (moving a big army piece by piece) and creates an interesting one (a big army eats your whole turn, so it cannot move and split up in the same turn). Keep it.

3.4 Siege machines march like soldiers

Siege machines move exactly as soldiers do, and count toward the size of the group.

LEFT OPEN

Is there a limit on army size?

SIDE ANSWER

Cap it at **30 soldiers** per player — the number you said out loud. It also caps how many pieces you have to make.

SIDE ANSWER

Balloons from the video game fit here neatly: a balloon spends one move token for **5 hexes**, flies over walls, water and enemies alike, and carries a single soldier. Only archers and towers can shoot one down.

SIDE ANSWER

A group has to *start* the move together on one hex. Otherwise a token could sweep up soldiers from all over the island, and the 5-hex limit would stop meaning anything.

“Boats move ten spaces for one move token, because the whole ocean is bigger than one island — and boats move faster than soldiers do.”

4.1 Ten hexes per move token

A boat moves up to **10 ocean hexes** for one move token — double a soldier, because the ocean is wide.

4.2 Fleets follow the army rule

Up to 4 boats move for one token. **5 or more** boats cost both move tokens and sail together as a fleet.

4.3 Transport boats are special

Ordinary boats cannot carry anyone. Moving soldiers or siege machines across water requires a **transport boat**, built for that job.

4.4 The dock

Each player has one **dock area** beside the board. Soldiers being shipped are lifted off the island and placed in the dock — they are at sea, so they cannot defend your island or be attacked on it. Leaving them standing on land while also sailing would be an unfair double.

4.5 Five aboard, three boats

5 soldiers per transport boat, and at most **3 transport boats** at once — so 15 soldiers can be at sea at any moment.

4.6 Landing

When a transport reaches its destination, take those soldiers out of the dock and place them where they land.

LEFT OPEN

Does unloading cost a card, or is it free?

SIDE ANSWER

Free. If the transport finishes its move on an ocean hex touching land, the soldiers step off onto that hex immediately. An extra card here would add a rule to remember without adding a decision to make.

LEFT OPEN

What happens if a loaded transport is sunk?

SIDE ANSWER

Everyone aboard is lost — take all 5 out of your dock. Brutal, and exactly right: it turns an invasion into a gamble and gives war boats a job worth doing, guarding the transports.

YOUR QUESTION

“Should there be fishing boats?”

SIDE ANSWER

Yes — and make them cheap. A fishing boat parked on an ocean hex next to your island earns **1 food per turn** and needs no token to stay there. It gives the sea a peaceful use, and gives raiders something to burn.

“So we’re going to have the wall, the outpost, the barracks — and how should the armoury work? Something like an armoury shop.”

5.1 Builders build where they stand

A builder can only build in the **hex it is standing on**. To build somewhere far away, you have to walk there first.

5.2 What you can build

BUILDING	WHAT IT DOES
Castle	Your heart. You start with one; lose it and you are out
Wall	Stops enemies on the ground. They must stop and break it
Outpost	A forward base away from the castle
Barracks	Trains soldiers
Armoury	A shop — spend gold to make your soldiers stronger
Windmill	Must sit next to a farm; turns food into more food
Tower	Shoots — and is one of only two things that can pop a balloon

5.3 Buildings live on paper

Rather than a model for every building, each player keeps a **building sheet**. Write the building down when you build it, tick it when it is upgraded, cross it out when it is destroyed. There is a printable sheet at the back of this packet.

YOU DISAGREED

One of you said four buildings per hex, the other said two.

SIDE ANSWER

Two buildings per hex — except your castle’s hex, which holds four. Your capital becomes the square worth defending hardest.

SIDE ANSWER

Walls should not count toward that limit. Put them on the **edges between hexes** instead of inside them — a wall is a line, and on a hex grid an edge is exactly that.

YOUR QUESTION

“Should we have upgrades for buildings or not?”

SIDE ANSWER

Yes, but **one level only**, costing the same again. One tick box per building keeps the paper simple.

SIDE ANSWER

Armoury: pay gold once for **+1 on every attack roll**, permanently. Simple, expensive, worth racing for.

SIDE ANSWER

Outpost: a builder may build in any hex **touching one**, not just the hex it stands on. That is how you expand without walking the builder home each time.

“The attacking is where you roll the dice.” · “Siege machines aren't as easy to kill, and they do more damage to walls — how are we going to calculate damage to walls?”

6.1 Attacks are dice

Spend your attack token to start a fight between two touching hexes. Both sides roll; the dice decide. Tokens got you there — they do not decide who wins.

6.2 Siege machines

- Harder to kill than a soldier
- Do far more damage to walls
- Need a transport boat to cross water (§ 4.3)

6.3 Balloons go over

Straight from the video game, and worth protecting: **balloons fly over walls**. Only **archers and towers** can shoot one down. A wall is not safety if the sky is open.

THE ONE BIG GAP

Wall damage was the question you ran out of time on. A worked-out answer is in the margin — try it as written for one game, then change the numbers rather than the system.

YOUR QUESTION

“How are we going to calculate damage to walls?”

SIDE ANSWER

Give every wall **3 blocks** of health, drawn as three tick boxes on your building sheet. Then, spending one attack token, roll one die per attacker:

ROLLING ON A WALL

Soldier 5–6 → 1 block

Siege 3–6 → 2 blocks

Balloon flies over — no roll

Cross out blocks as they break. At zero the wall is gone and the hex is open.

WHY THESE NUMBERS

A lone soldier needs roughly six turns to chew through a wall — hopeless, which is the point. One siege machine does it in about two. That is what makes siege machines worth building and walls worth having.

SIDE ANSWER

Soldier against soldier: both roll one die, higher roll wins and the loser is removed, defender wins ties. Add **+2 to the defender** if they are behind a standing wall.

“Four resources: food, wood, stone, gold. Beans for tokens.”

7.1 Four resources

RESOURCE	COMES FROM	SPENT ON
Food	Farms, fishing boats	Soldiers
Wood	Forest hexes	Boats, buildings
Stone	Mountain hexes	Walls, towers, sieges
Gold	Gold hexes	Armoury, upgrades

7.2 Beans are the money

Dried beans as tokens — four kinds, or four colours of paper square. Cheap, and you already have them.

7.3 Four kingdoms

Kingdom, Royal, Dark and Forest, the same four as the video game. Give each a small advantage so choosing matters.

KINGDOM	ADVANTAGE
Royal	Starts with extra gold
Forest	Farms give +1 food
Dark	Soldiers cost 1 less
Kingdom	Repairs walls for free

NOT YET DECIDED

How does anybody actually win?

SIDE ANSWER

Pick one before the first game rather than leaving it open — a game with no ending gets abandoned rather than finished.

CONQUEST

Destroy every other castle. The clearest, and the longest.

THE WONDER

First to build the Grand Cathedral, at an enormous price in all four resources. Lets a peaceful player win, and gives everyone else a clock they can see ticking.

SIDE ANSWER

For game one, use **both**: first to take every castle *or* finish the Wonder. Two ways to win means two ways to play, and you will learn twice as much from one evening.

SIDE ANSWER

Harvest rate to start with: **1 resource per matching hex per turn**. Round numbers are easy to fix later.

Every question either of you raised and did not finish. Decide them together and write the answer in the blank column — that column is the reason this page is printed.

QUESTION	SUGGESTED ANSWER	WHAT WE DECIDED
Damage to walls	3 blocks; soldier 5–6 for one, siege 3–6 for two	
Buildings per hex	Two, or four on the castle hex	
Building upgrades	Yes — one level, same cost again	
Fishing boats	Yes — 1 food a turn, parked next to your island	
Unloading soldiers	Free when the boat lands	
Sunk transports	Everyone aboard is lost	
How to win	All castles, or the Wonder	
Turn order	Roll a die, highest first, then clockwise	
Army size cap	30 soldiers	
Number of islands	One each, plus 2–3 small ones in the middle	
Balloon rules	5 hexes, over everything, carries one soldier	
Armoury shop	Gold once for +1 attack, permanently	
Outpost job	Build in any hex touching it	
Cost of everything	Not yet discussed — see § 9	

OUR OWN RULES

SHOPPING LIST

- ☐ Poster board or foam board — the islands
- ☐ Dried beans, four kinds — resources
- ☐ Two dice
- ☐ Small tokens for soldiers: LEGO, buttons or coins, in four colours
- ☐ Coloured paper — four kingdoms
- ☐ Scissors, glue, ruler, pencil
- ☐ The highlighter you already found
- ☐ A folder or box to keep it all in

BUILD IN THIS ORDER

- ☐ Cut 40 hexes and lay out two islands of 20
- ☐ Cut 20 ocean hexes to go between them
- ☐ Make 30 soldiers in two colours
- ☐ Print two building sheets and two turn cards
- ☐ **Play the tiny version** — castles, soldiers, walls, one way to win. Nothing else
- ☐ Then add boats and transports
- ☐ Then add siege machines and balloons
- ☐ Then add the four kingdoms and the armoury
- ☐ Draw the cover, and ask Dad to enhance it

SIDE ANSWER

Play the tiny version before anything is finished. Most board games die because the makers built every piece first and only then found out that a rule was no fun.

SIDE ANSWER

Costs are the one thing you never talked about. Do not agonise — write a price on everything in ten minutes, play, then fix whatever felt too cheap. Starting numbers:

Soldier	2 food
Wall	2 stone
Barracks	3 wood
Outpost	2 wood 1 stone
Tower	3 stone
Boat	3 wood
Transport	4 wood
Fishing boat	2 wood
Siege	3 wood 3 stone
Balloon	4 gold
Armoury	5 gold

SIDE ANSWER

Keep a notebook beside the board while you play and write down every argument. Arguments are where the next version comes from.

TURN CARDS

CUT OUT

PRINT, CUT ALONG THE BOXES, ONE FOR EACH PLAYER

YOUR TURN

Harvest — free 1 per hex you own

Move ×2 5 land / 10 sea

Build ×1 place or upgrade

Attack ×1 then roll dice

Up to 4 together 1 move token

5 or more together 2 move tokens

Soldier vs soldier high roll wins

Behind a wall defender +2

Wall 3 blocks

Soldier hits wall 5–6 → 1 block

Siege hits wall 3–6 → 2 blocks

Balloon flies over walls

Pops a balloon archers, towers

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Pops a balloon archers, towers

BUILDING SHEET

ONE EACH

PLAYER _____ KINGDOM _____

Write a building in when you build it. Tick *Level 2* when you upgrade it. Cross out the blocks as a wall breaks. Cross out the whole row when it is destroyed.

BUILDING	HEX	LEVEL 2	BLOCKS LEFT
Castle		☐	☐ ☐ ☐
		☐	☐ ☐ ☐
		☐	☐ ☐ ☐
		☐	☐ ☐ ☐
		☐	☐ ☐ ☐
		☐	☐ ☐ ☐
		☐	☐ ☐ ☐
		☐	☐ ☐ ☐
		☐	☐ ☐ ☐
		☐	☐ ☐ ☐
		☐	☐ ☐ ☐
		☐	☐ ☐ ☐
		☐	☐ ☐ ☐
		☐	☐ ☐ ☐

THE DOCK — SOLDIERS AT SEA

Five soldiers per transport, three transports at once. Put the pieces on this box while they sail.

Transport 1

☐☐☐☐☐

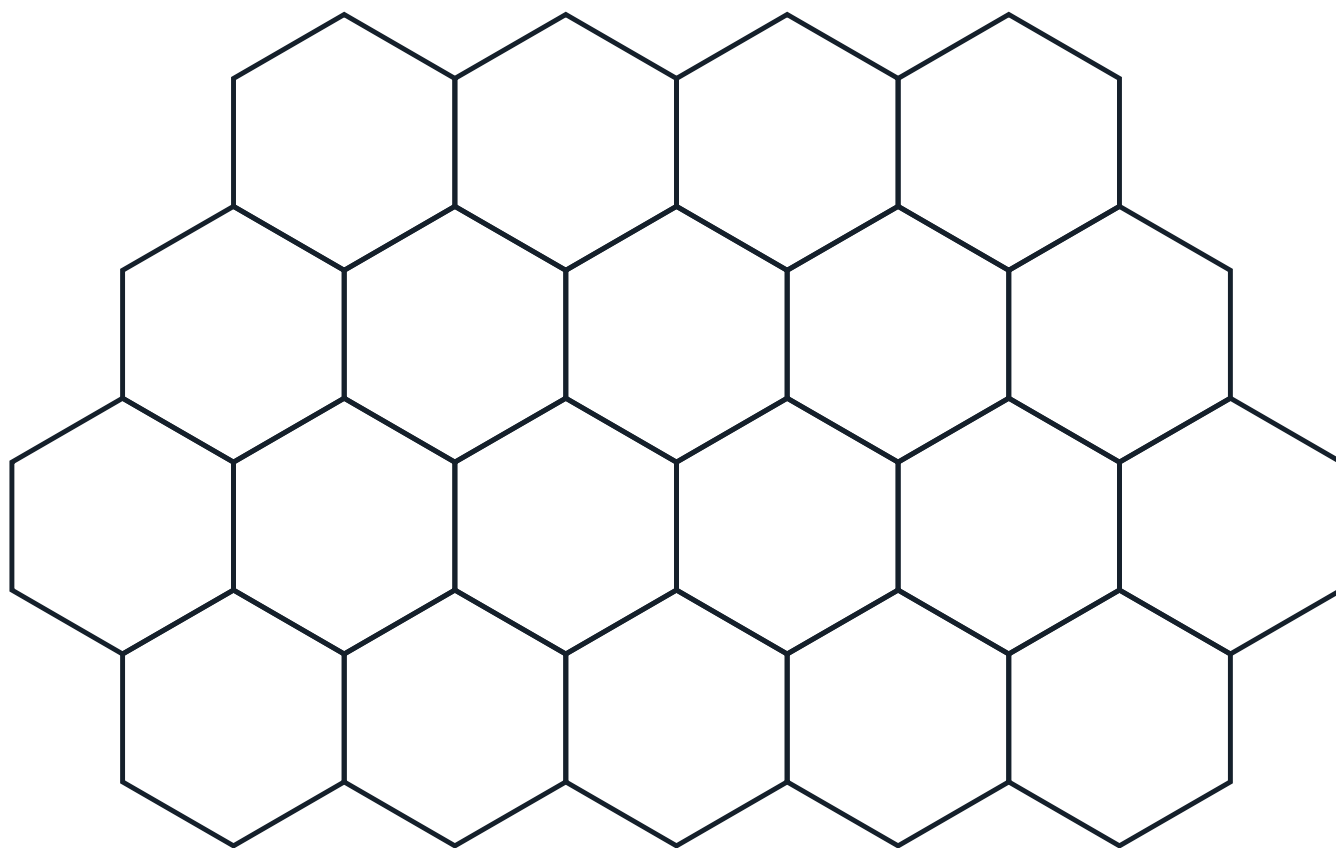
Transport 2

☐☐☐☐☐

Transport 3

☐☐☐☐☐

An island of exactly 20 hexagons, at playing size. Trace it onto card once for every player.



ROWS OF 4 · 5 · 6 · 5 = 20 LAND HEXES

Blank hexes for drawing the ocean, the small middle islands, or a map you like better than ours.

